Accent marks

Two rules tell you where the stress falls. A written accent marks a word that breaks them.

casa · **ha**blan · **li**bros

ends in a vowel, n or s: stress the second-to-last syllable

ha**blar** · ciu**dad** · re**loj**

ends in any other consonant: stress the last syllable

ca**fé** · can**ción** · **ár**bol · **fá**cil

breaks the rule: the accent shows where the stress goes

teléfono · **mú**sica · **rá**pido

stress three from the end: always written

hablo · ha**bló**

I speak · he spoke: the accent changes the meaning

ACCENTS THAT TELL TWO WORDS APART

sí yes	si if
tú you	tu your
él he	el the
mí me	mi my
sé I know	se oneself, etc.
té tea	te you, to you
más more	mas but (rare)
dé give (a form of dar)	de of, from
qué, cómo, dónde… in questions	que, como, donde… elsewhere

Capitals too: capital letters keep their accents: Él, Ángel, ÁFRICA.

SOURCES

- RAE–ASALE, Ortografía de la lengua española (2010): the rules of written accentuation and the diacritic accent (tilde diacrítica).